

Cat & Company

Issue 2

Beyond Belief

24 pp

David White

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Page 1

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The laboratory/shop of the **Mark IX Corvette**. The walls are surrounded by a variety of tools; these include workbenches and a structure that looks like, and is, a glove-box and fume hood. In the foreground, the **Neural Interface** lurks in the middle of the room. Behind it, **Peter Cat** and **Camillo Skragg** stand on one side of the open door, and **Jinx Bubastis** and **Penny Skragg** stand on the other. **Jinx Bubastis** gestures towards the walls. **Penny Skragg** looks directly at the **Neural Interface**.

Jinx Bubastis

So, this is the lab. I've been using it as storage.

Penny Skragg

What's *that*?

Jinx Bubastis

It's a *neural interface*, a device that can directly *alter* your *brain*.

Penny Skragg

Why does the bed part have straps?

Jinx Bubastis (ignoring Penny Skragg's question)

The former owners of this ship were using it for *recreational purposes*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat leans on the wall, and **Camillo Skragg** stands with his arms crossed in front of him. **Peter Cat** face is deadpan.

Peter Cat

It's a neat bit of tech. Do you need an interactive visualization in 5-D?
This thing can *expand your senses* enough to do that.

Camillo Skragg

Or make you *trip balls*.

Peter Cat (deadpan)

Yes.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis leads the others out of the lab into the narrow hallway. She wants to change the subject quickly. **Peter Cat** follows closely behind.

Peter Cat (whispering to Jinx)

About these *former owners*...

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat looks at **Jinx Bubastis** with a note of sternness. **Jinx Bubastis** pouts in a gesture of feigned offense.

Peter Cat (whispering to Jinx)

...are they *still alive*?

Jinx Bubastis (interjection)

Hey!

Peter Cat

I *know* you, Jinx.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat and **Jinx Bubastis** frame **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** as they proceed down the hallway.

Jinx Bubastis

I *paid good money* for this ship!

Bought it off some *drug smugglers* who owed their *suppliers*.

Got it cheap!

Page 2

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg whispers to Camillo Skragg, who cocks an eyebrow.

Penny Skragg (*whisper*)

Those two are totally screwing.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg takes a close look as Peter Cat and Jinx Bubastis walk up to them in the hallway.

Camillo Skragg (*whisper*)

I hope they're not loud, this ship is *tiny*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis catches up to Camillo Skragg and Penny Skragg.

Jinx Bubastis

So, let's head back to the cargo bay.

I'd love to hear where you guys want to go next!

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg crosses her arms in front of her.

Yeah, I have some *ideas*.

That thing you were talking about, with the *human colonies*?

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The landscape of the Moon is visible through the window in the cargo bay. Jinx Bubastis walks towards the center of the room, and Camillo Skragg gesticulates towards the Moonscape. Peter Cat and Penny Skragg trail behind: Peter Cat shrugs a little.

Camillo Skragg

It sounds *crazy*! It was a huge deal when *humans* managed to land *here*!

Peter Cat (*to Penny Skragg*)

You guys *really* call it "*The Moon*"? Isn't that kind of *generic*?

Penny Skragg (*to Peter Cat*)

I like to think we named the other ones after it.

Peter Cat (*to Penny Skragg, shrugs*)

Makes sense.

Title

Beyond Belief

Page 3

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The cargo bay is dark, and a star map floats in the air. Tens of stars are marked with bounding rectangles. **Jinx Bubastis** stares at the floating display and gestures grandly, while **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** try to understand what they are seeing. In the background, **Peter Cat** facepalms.

Jinx Bubastis

Shithead! Set the windows to *opaque*.

Display a map of stars within 50 C.U. and mark *known archaeological sites*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg points to a small red star marked with a bounding box.

Penny Skragg

How about that one?

Jinx Bubastis

No problem. Let's go!

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Inside the cockpit, **Jinx Bubastis** sits at the helm and runs through a take-off check-list on one of the ceiling displays. Behind her sits **Peter Cat** and **Penny Skragg**. **Camillo Skragg** sits next to **Penny Skragg**, opposite the navigator that's been duct-taped into the mounting rack. It's... cramped.

Penny Skragg

So, what's *FTL travel* like?

Peter Cat

If everything *works*...

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Mark IX corvette** takes off from the surface of the Moon – booms are in the 120° cruising position. Depicted realistically, this won't be nearly as visually interesting as taking off from the Earth.

Peter Cat

...it's pretty *boring*.

Page 4

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Nightstalker hangs in space; an establishing shot, with the bridge bump on the main hull front and center.

Panel 1a (*small square inset in Panel 1, left*):

Close-up on **The Eye**, who has an important announcement she is delivering with gusto.

The Eye

We're doing another take!

Panel 1b (*small square insert in Panel 1, right*):

Thresher leans with both hands on the front-facing low rear console. Small image.

Thresher

Incoming communication from Strategic Coordination!

Victor Bravo (*off panel, from below and to the left*)

On screen, Thresher!

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo stands in front of the command chair in the center, arms akimbo. **Jolt** sits on her chair to his right.

Jolt

It appears to be a set of coordinates.

Victor Bravo

To an il-
ul-
uh!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo yells, shaking with rage.

Victor Bravo

FUCK!
FUCK!
FUCK!

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Nightstalker hangs in space; an establishing shot, with the bridge bump on the main hull front and center.

Panel 4a (*small square inset in Panel 4, left*):

Close-up on **The Eye**, who has an important announcement she is delivering with gusto.

The Eye

So, another take!

Panel 4b (*small square insert in Panel 4, right*):

Thresher leans with both hands on the front-facing low rear console. Small image.

Thresher

Incoming communication from Strategic Coordination!

Victor Bravo (*off panel, from below and to the left*)

On screen, Thresher!

Page 5

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo stands in front of the command chair in the center, arms akimbo. **Jolt** sits on her chair to his right.

Jolt

It appears to be a set of coordinates—
—to an illegal underground installation providing provisions to criminals!

Victor Bravo

Wha—?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo explodes, screaming with rage at **Jolt**, who recoils. **Thresher** tries to intervene.

Victor Bravo

THAT'S MY FUCKING LINE, BITCH!

Thresher

Victor! Whoa!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo collapses into his chair, shaking.

Victor Bravo

Sorry.
Sorry.
Just *lost* it there.
Fuck, what's wrong with me?

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jolt is a little shaken by **Victor Bravo's** outburst, but turns to him and tries to be supportive.

Jolt

I'm sorry, Victor.
I was just trying to help.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jolt turns to the front view screen, towards the reader. She has an expression of disgust.

Jolt

“an illegal underground installation providing provisions to criminals”?
Sadistic little *nerds*!
That doesn't even *flow*!

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Eye turns a little towards **Jolt**, although she doesn't look at her directly. (See the notes about **The Eye's** eye sockets and her 360° field of view, this is a theatrical gesture.) **Thresher** also turns towards **Jolt**. **Victor Bravo** slumps in the command chair and cradles his head in his hands.

Jolt

Eye?

Put the script for this scene up on the viewscreen.

I think we need to do a quick *re-write*!

Page 6

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Mark IX corvette** approaches the Earth-like planet closely orbiting a red dwarf star.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

So we arrived at the planet Penny picked.

Penny and I were still pretty sure this was bullshit, but we had to see for ourselves.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg stands in the foreground on a field of mutated long grass. The **Mark IX corvette** is landed in the background. The red sun hangs low in the sky.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

The rest of the surface was dominated by some kind of lichen-like growths, but the area around the ruins were covered in long grass.

The air smelled funny, like ozone and must.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

In the background, the ruined walls of the **Atlantean archaeological site** protrude from the overgrown grass. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** walk towards them, with **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** taking up the rear.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

It didn't look like much at first.

The stone outer walls were crumbling.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg walks through a path between two crumbling "houses" inside the walled area.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

I'm no archaeologist, but I've seen pictures of *Göbleki Tepe*.

What we saw wasn't *proof*, but it asked questions I couldn't answer.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg looks at a stone staircase leading down into the darkness.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

The staircase heading underground was on the edge of "town".

Something about it made the hairs on the back of my neck stand up.

Page 7

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat follows closely behind **Camillo Skragg** as they descend the staircase. Light comes from a glowing sphere floating between them. **Peter Cat** seems alert. **Camillo Skragg** is struggling to understand what he is seeing.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

Peter stayed close behind as we descended.
As for what happened next?

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-up on a tense-looking **Camillo Skragg**.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

That was one of them *Proustian* fucking memories.
The kind you use as a *scaffold* for *future experiences*.

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The staircase leads to a long corridor underground. **Camillo Skragg** looks down the tunnel into the darkness. **Penny Skragg** examines one of a set of holes in the stone wall.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg):

Peter and Jinx told us the tunnel was used for the *shunts* that brought humans to this world.
Penny pointed out that structures like that tend to be *graves*.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg holds a crumbling human skull; the cubbyholes are being used as an ossuary.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg):

We found *proof*.
Obviously human remains.
An ancient *ossuary*.
But that proof entailed some facts we weren't ready for.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg faces the reader, as he looks down the darkened corridor. He looks astonished.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg):

Facts that were about to be *demonstrated*.

Page 8

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg's expression shifts from astonishment to terror. **Peter Cat** moves behind him, on full alert.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

Back in college I had a really bad finals week.
Stayed up for two weeks on *speed*.
By the end, I was *seeing things* in my *peripheral vision*.
Ghostly, *dark things*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg turns to run away. **Peter Cat** stretches out his arm and begins blasting down the corridor.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

The *things* that came for us weren't *ghostly*...
...they were very *solid*...
...and I could see them in the pitch darkness.
Then this *guy* I just got to know stretches out his arm and does a *convincing* impersonation of a *30mm autocannon*.

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis gathers **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** together while **Peter Cat** continues blasting the unseen horrors coming from the end of the dark hallway.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

When it was all over, they told us about what *those things* were.
They called it "Black Oil".
A waste material produced after a *shunt* collapses and starts to *rot*.
They said our *presence* "woke it up".
Gotta admit, I'm not used to *my waste oil* trying to *kill me* or *eat my soul*.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

From front to back, **Peter Cat**, **Camillo Skragg**, **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Penny Skragg** seem to transform into lightning; the walls are illuminated by the electrical discharge.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

I was a little surprised when Peter stopped blasting.
Turns out *Jinx* had a trick up her sleeve.
Teleportation.
She can *do that*.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat, **Camillo Skragg**, **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Penny Skragg** appear in the cargo bay of the **Mark IX corvette**. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** seem disoriented. Small electrical discharges spark in the background.

Box (narration, Camillo Skragg)

I used to work with *soldiers*.
They told me they had a *metric* for *fear*, the "Pucker Factor".
One was mild surprise, ten was imminent death.
This was about a *seven*.

Page 9

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis sits at the helm of the **Mark IX corvette**. **Peter Cat** sits at one of the stations behind her, and does not look happy.

Box (*upper left*)

Shortly, after a hurried departure...

Jinx Bubastis

Ok, the humans are recovering in the other stateroom.
We're going to need fuel.

Peter Cat

I do *not* want to return to Corporate space, Jinx.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis turns to face **Peter Cat** and tries to convince him. **Peter Cat** looks at her with obvious suspicion.

Jinx Bubastis

We don't have a lot of options.

Peter Cat

There are *always* options, especially for people like us.
We *both* know what this looks like, Jinx.
We end up at some pirate station that just *happens* to be raided by *Honor Guard*...

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis looks a little crestfallen.

Jinx Bubastis

All right.
You're not wrong.
What do they say? "Show, don't tell"?

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis and **Peter Cat** both look at the terminal in **Peter Cat's** station. **Jinx Bubastis** points at the screen. **Peter Cat** rubs his temples.

Jinx Bubastis

"Fun Division" *has* been in contact with me.
I *misdirected* them, sent them to a *different* resupply station!
I haven't responded to their attempts to work a booking!

Peter Cat

Jinx, didn't you ever *wonder* how dumb "faces" like me catch smart "heels" like you?

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks up at **Jinx Bubastis**. His face has softened a little.

Peter Cat

I have no idea how “Fun Division” does it, but they always manage to give “heels” this weird *genre blindness*.

It’s why your *brilliant plans* never seem to work!

“Fun Division” works with *branching scripts*, they’ll have a *backup plan* if they’re planning a booking.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis slumps in her seat, looking deflated. **Peter Cat** touches her knee, leans towards her, and smiles.

Jinx Bubastis (sighs)

...crap...

Peter Cat

Hey, stop that!

I’m sorry I mistrusted you.

Main thing is, we get the humans out of there before they get hurt.

Jinx Bubastis

Yeah.

Page 10

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Demonlayer's sanctum on the **Bastard Sun**. **Demonlayer** is looking intently at a star map of the outskirts of Corporate space, tiny dots of light with a few highlighted with bounding cubes. A translucent orange truncated cone with rounded edges is overlaid over a few of these points. As a side effect, **Demonlayer's** face is illuminated almost as if she were holding a flashlight and shining it upwards from beneath her face. **Champion** stands close behind her, arms crossed. **Bearcat** is side-eyeing **Champion**. **Killotron** stands on **Demonlayer's** other side, awaiting orders.

Box (upper left)

The *Bastard Sun*, warship of M-Seven...

Demonlayer

Our quarry approaches—

Champion (grumbles)

Give or take a few C.U.

Demonlayer

—there are three plausible destinations where they could resupply.
Killotron, plot a course into *interphase*, place us so we can quickly materialize in any of the re-entry points.

Killotron

I'll calculate the hyperion's curve,
A phantom in the Mistress' directive.
Track through nebula's breath, unrelenting—
Your shadow, a steel net in my grip.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Champion turns to **Bearcat**, and **Bearcat** answers smugly.

Champion

Hey Bearcat, this ship can *do* that?

Bearcat

Mistress is a *genius* and a *wizard*.

Champion

But the *robot* is doing the work!

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Demonlayer turns to face **Killotron** with a tight smile.

Killotron

Calculations weave through void's embrace,
A path etched where shadows dare to dance.
Mistress' will – my pulse, my endless task.

Demonlayer

Well done, Killotron.
Lay in the course—

Panel 4 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Pull back to see **Bearcat**, **Champion**, **Demonlayer**, and **Killotron** standing in the sanctum. A purple blob overlaps with the orange truncated cone on the starmap from Panel 1.

Demonlayer

—now we *lie in wait*.

Page 11

Warning: This page contains International Phonetic Alphabet characters.

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Close-up on **Camillo Skragg**. He is sitting in a room dimly illuminated by colored lights, at a booth. He looks like he is asking a rhetorical question.

Box (upper left)

Meanwhile...

Camillo Skragg

A gay bar—
—in SPACE?

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg holds a shotglass and points off-panel towards the stage.

Penny Skragg

The band's doing a pretty good job on "Groove Is in the Heart".
Catgirl "Lady Miss Kier" is killing it!

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Pull back. From left to right, **Peter Cat** has just finished his shot, and is looking intently at his shotglass, considering if he wants another. **Camillo Skragg** sits in front of two shotglasses, one empty, one full. He tried to ignore the full one, got distracted, and finished the now empty one. **Penny Skragg** sits in front of the bottle of "vodka" and holds her shotglass in her hand. **Jinx Bubastis** has a shotglass upside-down in front of her, and is sipping on a bottle of water. They are all sitting in front of a round table in a large, comfortable-looking booth. **Penny Skragg** turns to ask **Jinx Bubastis** a question, which she answers with mild amusement.

Penny Skragg

Speaking of *catgirls*, your name isn't *really* "Jinx Bubastis", is it?

Jinx Bubastis

It's pretty close. The proper pronunciation is /d͡z̞ŋ˥kai mɾlo beβeˈstoʒ/.

Penny Skragg

Wait, like "Dz-nnn-kai... Marr-lo... Beh-beh... sto-ZH"?

Jinx Bubastis

Close. The /ŋ/ and /ɾ/ are vowels you'll have some *anatomical* issues with.

Penny Skragg

Your *middle name* is "Marlo"?

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg turns to **Peter Cat**.

Camillo Skragg

What about you?

Peter Cat

"350125".

Camillo Skragg

What?

Peter Cat

It's my *clone designation*.

Series 350 Engineer, Phenotype 125.

Clones get boring names.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis turns to **Peter Cat**.

Jinx Bubastis

They should be about *halfway* through the *refueling*.

Peter Cat

If anything *stupid* happens, we *bug out*.

Jinx Bubastis

Yup.

Page 12

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer points at a blinking dot on her star map. **Champion** stands behind her, arms folded.

Demonlayer

They have *arrived*.

Champion

Our *quarry*?

Demonlayer

Our *bait*.

Bearcat, transmit this location to those *Corporate lackeys*.

Bearcat (*off-panel*)

Yes, Mistress...

Demonlayer

I'll set the *interocitor* to view the station *interior*.

We cannot afford *surprises*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer's face twists with disgust, and she points to the booth where **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** are sitting. **Champion** looks surprised.

Demonlayer (*shouting*)

WHAT ARE *THOSE THINGS* DOING THERE!

Champion

Aliens? In the *club*?

Bearcat (*off-panel*)

It's more likely than you think!

Demonlayer (*shouting*)

THE *INVADERS* MUST NEVER FEEL SAFE IN *OUR SPACE*!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

In the club, **Demonlayer** appears on stage, pointing at **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** in the audience. **Demonlayer's** face is contorted with rage. The **Musicians** scatter, and the **Singer** has a problem with her platform heels and falls on her hands and knees.

Box (*upper left, Champion*)

"Wait! Don't do something stupid!"

Demonlayer (*screaming*)

REEEEEEEE!!

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat stands up, holding a shotglass in his right hand. **Jinx Bubastis** pulls **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** under the table.

Peter Cat (*grumbles*)

Demonlayer!? Oh, *fuck off...*

I got this!

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A clearer view of the stage. An incredibly fast moving, smoky streak flies through the back wall, leaving it unharmed. Some **Musicians** look at the place where **Demonlayer** was. The **Singer** gets to her feet.

SF/X

yoink

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Singer** and the **Musicians** resume their set.

Page 13

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Nightstalker hangs in space; an establishing shot, with the bridge bump on the main hull front and center.

Panel 1a (small square inset in Panel 1, left):

Close-up on **The Eye**, who has an important announcement she is delivering with gusto.

The Eye

Take *five*, this is the *good one*!

Panel 1b (small square insert in Panel 1, right):

Thresher leans with both hands on the front-facing low rear console. Small image.

Thresher*

Incoming communication from Strategic Coordination!

Victor Bravo (off panel, from below and to the left)

On screen, Thresher!

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo stands in front of the command chair in the center, arms akimbo. **Jolt** sits on her chair to his right.

Jolt

It appears to be a set of coordinates.

Victor Bravo

It's one of those *pirate stations* that cater to *weirdos*, *freaks*, and *drug addicts*.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Eye pretends to look at the view screen.

The Eye

It appears to be abandoned.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A light blinks on **Thresher's** console. He looks over to **Jolt**, who nervously returns his look.

Thresher

Uh...

A new set of coordinates, sir!

There's been an *incident*!

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo barks commands to his crew. In the background, **Jolt** appears relieved.

Bring it around!

Lay in a course!

Dome lights on!

ENGAGE!

Page 14

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

An exterior view of the **Station**. The **Mark IX corvette** flies into the foreground. In the background, a tiny figure – **Demonlayer** – cartwheels through space, leaving a trail of blood droplets.

Jinx Bubastis (from inside crew hull)

Peter's on board!

Jumping to *interphase*!

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis sits at the helm inside the bridge of the **Mark IX corvette**.

Jinx Bubastis

This gets us *five extra degrees of freedom* and *non-commuting EM fields*!

Meaning – we can *evade pursuit*!

Here we *go*!

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

On the **Bastard Sun**, in **Demonlayer's** sanctum, **Champion** facepalms. **Killotron** beeps with annoyance.

Champion

Materialize the ship so I can recover *dumb-ass's* body.

Killotron

Though my data screams she's wrong,

My Mistress is not a dumb-ass.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Bastard Sun** has materialized; **Champion** has grabbed **Demonlayer's** body and drags her back to the ship, leaving a trail of blood droplets.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Demonlayer lies on a floating gurney that **Champion** and **Killotron** are pushing into a sick bay on board the **Bastard Sun**. **Demonlayer** has a prominent, bleeding wound in her shoulder where **Peter Cat** rammed a shotglass through her body.

Demonlayer (weakly)

...it's only a flesh wound...

Champion

I didn't know you had a *sense of humor*.

Demonlayer (weakly)

...that wasn't a joke...

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Bearcat looks faintly ridiculous in a face mask and surgical scrubs. He stands next to a table on instruments and prepares an injection of a local anesthetic. **Champion** turns to **Killotron** as they push the gurney towards him.

Champion

We're letting *him* do surgery?

Killotron

His fangs may gnash, but his blade knows its place—
To carve through chaos and stitch what's torn asunder.

Page 15

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Nightstalker** materializes, heading towards the **Station** and behind it the **Bastard Sun**.

The Eye (*from inside bridge dome*)

It's the *Bastard Sun*!

M-Seven's flagship!

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

On the bridge of the **Nightstalker**, **Victor Bravo** barks orders.

Victor Bravo

Slow us down!

Keep the *Station* between *us* and *its guns*!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

In the sick bay of the **Bastard Sun**, **Demonlayer** sits up from her bed. A bloody bandage covers the wound in her shoulder.

Demonlayer

See! All better now!

Computer! Bring us about and *accelerate*!

Prepare for jump.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer turns to **Killotron** and gives the order. **Bearcat** holds a bloody shotglass in a pair of forceps.

Demonlayer

Killotron – set course for the heart of the cancer killing our kind!

Killotron

Burn through the stars where shadows breed,

A trajectory etched in her command–

The core of the plague, we'll sever its thread.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

On the bridge of the **Nightstalker**, **The Eye** pretends to look at the view screen.

The Eye

They're *fleeing*!

Victor Bravo (*off-panel*)

Then we *pursue*!

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Station** hangs in space as the **Nightstalker** departs; peaceful at last, and intact.

Page 16

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Inside the **Mark IX corvette**, inside the stateroom shared by **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis**. They cuddle in bed, **Peter Cat** sitting up a bit, **Jinx Bubastis** cuddles between his left arm and chest. **Peter Cat** looks exhausted.

Box (upper left)

Much later, in Peter and Jinx's stateroom...

Peter Cat

"Fun Division" somehow turns *everyone* into a *paranoid narcissist*.
I *really* thought this was about us.

Jinx Bubastis

We had no way to know.
That was some *underwhelming bullshit* alright.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Close up on **Jinx Bubastis**, who looks up at **Peter Cat**.

Jinx Bubastis

I want you to *promise me something*.

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis rolls over to look **Peter Cat** in the eyes. She gesticulates a little for emphasis – she's angry, but not at him. He looks at her intently.

Jinx Bubastis

Never forget what they tried to do to you.
They wanted to *erase* you.
Literally.
I was going to say, "you owe them nothing", but that's bullshit.
You owe them *pain*.
Make those fuckers pay.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat leans back. He's thinking.

Peter Cat

I still want to be *good guy*.
I want to *fly around and save people*.
But you're *right*...

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Mark IX corvette** continues on its slow jump back to Earth. The speech balloon comes from the crew hull.

Peter Cat (from inside ship)

...if we see those assholes again
we'll put them in the ground.

Page 17

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The mess hall on the **Mark IX corvette**. **Jinx Bubastis** and **Penny Skragg** quietly discuss a sensitive topic, while **Camillo Skragg** looks at a snack vending machine and asks **Peter Cat** for advice.

Box (upper left)

Later, after several hours of sleep...

Jinx Bubastis (to Penny Skragg)

Ours don't tend to *do that* unless we've been exposed to *toxins* or *radiation*.
You say this is a *regular* thing?

Penny Skragg (to Jinx Bubastis)

Yeah. It's not pressing, but...

Jinx Bubastis (to Penny Skragg)

No problem! We have extensive *medical supplies*, I can probably adapt something.
Still, I understand wanting something *familiar*.

Camillo Skragg (to Peter Cat)

I'm trying to figure out if I can *eat* any of this.
So, that one looks like a *sausage*.
Why is it covered in *fur*?

Peter Cat (to Camillo Skragg)

Well, that's how we *like* 'em.
I guess you could *peel* it first.

Panel 2 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis, **Penny Skragg**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Peter Cat** sit at the dining table in the middle of the room.

Jinx Bubastis

So, to answer everybody's unspoken question— *interphase flight* is FTL, but *subjective travel time* gets *weird*.

Peter Cat

How's everyone doing with the *day/night* cycles?

Camillo Skragg

No complaints here!
So, *how long*?

Jinx Bubastis

We'll be arriving at *Earth* in about five of these cycles.

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg turns to **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Camillo Skragg** talks with **Peter Cat**.

Penny Skragg (to Jinx Bubastis)

I hope we don't seem *ungrateful*.
It's been an *awesome* experience.

Jinx Bubastis (to Penny Skragg)

It was a *clusterfuck*, but we all *survived*.

Penny Skragg (to Jinx Bubastis)

Well, yeah, but that's what made it *awesome*!

Camillo Skragg (to Peter Cat)

So you gotta explain this *radio mining* to me.

Peter Cat (to Camillo Skragg)

It's pretty *straightforward*.

We have a copy of the *software distribution* used to decode the signals.

We can try setting it up in the *cargo bay*.

Page 18

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks up at a projection of a 525-line TV image of the Apollo 11 moon landing. **Peter Cat** looks up from a folding terminal. **Penny Skragg** crosses her arms and asks a question.

Box (*upper left*)

4 cycles until Earth...

Peter Cat

So, is it working now?

Camillo Skragg

Looks *good*!

Penny Skragg

So we have *TV* now?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Close-up on **Camillo Skragg**, who is grinning.

Camillo Skragg

Not just *TV* – everything *ever* broadcast.

Penny Skragg (*off-panel*)

Just *old* stuff?

Camillo Skragg

Nah, new stuff, too!

Most *cable* from *satellite uplinks*, most *digital broadcasts*.

Everything.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks up from the terminal. **Camillo Skragg** deadpans.

Peter Cat

We even had a–

–what did you call it?– an “*MPREG*” decoder in the *software distribution*.

Camillo Skragg (*deadpan*)

MPEG, Peter.

MPEG.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg points at the image. **Peter Cat** looks towards her and answers.

Penny Skragg

How do you pick out what you want to see?

Peter Cat

It's difficult.

You have to pick the correct point in the *light-shell*, set up the decoders, and forward the stream to a device that can display the output.

Then the *signals* will replay like they did when *originally broadcast*.

Penny Skragg

So the *remote control*'s 160 light-years across.

Panel 5 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat goes back to typing on his terminal. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** watch the flag being planted during Apollo 11.

Penny Skragg

It's *overwhelming*!

Peter Cat

Yes.

And when presented with an *overwhelming* amount of data—
—*build an index!*

Page 19

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg sits at one of the workbenches in the shop. He is wearing an improvised headset/neck brace that holds a small black box to the back of his head – a neural pickup communicating with his cerebellum. He is making a gesture as if picking something out of thin air with his thumb and forefinger with his arm crooked. A mechanical arm on a stand – a detached portion of a powered armor frame – duplicates this gesture. **Peter Cat** monitors a display.

Box (upper left)

3 cycles to Earth...

Camillo Skragg

It's the damndest thing–
–I have fine motor control!

Peter Cat

No pins-and-needles sensations?
It's looking clean over here.

Camillo Skragg

I think it's working.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg enters the shop. She seems mildly surprised at what she's seeing.

Penny Skragg

Hey!
What are *you guys* doing?

Camillo Skragg (off-panel)

A proof of concept.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-up of **Camillo Skragg**, who has turned to face **Penny Skragg** off-panel in the foreground.

Camillo Skragg

I've been thinking about what we'll do when we get *back home*.
I have *more options* in a suit of *bullet-proof armor*.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat looks up from the terminal.

Peter Cat

Your *nervous systems* are incredibly *adaptable*.
The *neural pickups* worked with *minimal tweaking*.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg looks over towards the **Neural Interface**.

Penny Skragg

You *don't* say...

Page 20

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

In the mess, **Camillo Skragg** sits at the table, looking into a folding portable terminal. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** walk in together.

Box (upper left)

2 cycles to Earth...

Camillo Skragg

Morning!

Peter Cat

Morning, Camillo.

Are you guys sleeping OK?

Camillo Skragg

Not really. There's this *hum*.

The *head's* amazing, though.

Peter Cat

With *shed fur* and *dander*, these ships need *good ventilation*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis and **Peter Cat** sit down near **Camillo Skragg**, who is looking something up on the terminal.

Jinx Bubastis

Has anyone seen *Penny*?

Camillo Skragg

No.

Let me see if I can *look up* what she's been *doing*.

She made a *query* on the *topic index* for "martial arts movies".

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg scratches his chin as he reads the screen. **Jinx Bubastis** looks like she has been shocked, wide-eyed with horrified surprise.

Camillo Skragg

Then she sent the *stream* to the *shop*.

Oh, *shit*.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg, **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Peter Cat** rush off-panel towards the shop, like there's some kind of serious emergency.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Black panel. **Penny Skragg's** POV, such as it is.

Peter Cat (not visible)

—slowly. I've stopped the data flow.

Camillo Skragg (*not visible*)

She's stopped *spasming*.

Jinx Bubastis (*not visible*)

For what it's worth, her mind seems to be *intact*.

Penny Skragg (*weakly*)

...whoa...

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A stripe of light from the PoV of **Penny Skragg**, as she slowly opens her eyes.

Penny Skragg (*weakly*)

...I can do kung fu...

Page 21

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg sits on the bed of the **Neural interface**. **Jinx Bubastis** holds a flashlight in one hand and performs an eye-tracking exam on her.

Jinx Bubastis

Look into the light and try to follow it with your eyes.

Penny Skragg

OK.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat and **Camillo Skragg** carefully examine an improvised EEG graph displayed on a terminal.

Peter Cat

Most of the *data flow* went into her *cerebellum*.

This is a graph of the current *electrical activity* in her *brain*.

Camillo Skragg

I'm no *neurologist*, but this looks *fine*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis places her fingers near **Penny Skragg's** temples and looks deep into her eyes – a very iconic/trope-y “mind probe.”

Jinx Bubastis

I'm not *sensing* any *abnormalities*.

Her *misadventure* with the *neural interface* didn't cause *permanent damage*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis straightens up and looks **Penny Skragg** in the eye.

Jinx Bubastis

How are you *feeling*?

Penny Skragg

Good!

I can do kung fu!

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks concerned. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** look at **Penny Skragg** with some alarm. **Penny Skragg** is grinning.

Camillo Skragg

Are you *sure* she's OK?

Page 22

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The cargo bay of the **Mark IX corvette**. Off to the side, **Peter Cat** talks to an alarmed-looking **Camillo Skragg**. **Jinx Bubastis** and **Penny Skragg** face off to spar.

Camillo Skragg

Wait, you're telling me *mind-reading magic woman* can—?

Peter Cat

Demonic strength.

I'll step in if things get out of hand.

Penny Skragg

I *can* do kung fu!

Jinx Bubastis

Show, don't tell, sweetie.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis punches with her right fist; **Penny Skragg** effortlessly dodges by leaning to the right.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis punches with her left fist; **Penny Skragg** effortlessly dodges by leaning to the left.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis punches with her right fist, but is caught in a throw by **Penny Skragg**.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis lands on her feet and slides backwards, her fingers digging a little into the floor.

Jinx Bubastis

All right.

That *blow* you *blocked* to start the throw?

It should have *shattered your arm*.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg boggles at what he is seeing. **Peter Cat** observes carefully, one eyebrow cocked.

Camillo Skragg

What the *hell* was that!?

Peter Cat

It appears your *niece* can do *kung fu*—

—or some reasonable *simulation* thereof.

Page 23

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The mess hall. **Penny Skragg** sits at the table next to **Camillo Skragg** and tries to reassure him that she's OK. **Camillo Skragg** gesticulates with obvious doubt. **Peter Cat** is quiet and listening carefully. **Jinx Bubastis** looks at **Camillo Skragg** and does her best to level with him.

Camillo Skragg

How is this even *possible*!?

Jinx Bubastis

My best guess?

Some kind of *latent paranormal ability*.

Penny Skragg

I just *go through the motions*, and *things happen*.

Story of my life, really.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis as she faces **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** on the opposite end.

Jinx Bubastis

Phenomenological manipulation with a *somatic trigger*.

A reality warper, in other words, who must act out her changes to affect them.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis continues talking. **Peter Cat** listens quietly and thoughtfully.

Jinx Bubastis

It's not unheard of for *latent reality warpers* to go *unnoticed* for a long time.

The effects can be subtle, like *persistent good luck* or a history of *unlikely events*.

Panel 4 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Very similar in composition to Panel 1. **Camillo Skragg** lays his hands palm-down on the table. **Peter Cat** looks up and says something.

Camillo Skragg

Or building an *experimental radio* with her uncle—

—and then *aliens actually show up*?

Peter Cat

Yeah.

That's a pretty good example.

Page 24

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis pokes her head into the shop, as **Peter Cat** analyzes data on a terminal.

Box (*upper left*)

1 cycle to Earth...

Jinx Bubastis

Hey, Peter!
What're *you* up to?

Peter Cat

It looks like Penny's reckless experiment with the *neural interface* has gotten us some data that will be *really* helpful for Camillo's *project*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat gets up from the terminal, and starts walking over to join **Jinx Bubastis** in the hallway.

Peter Cat

It will let me derive a *bidirectional translation matrix* that will let humans use *neural interfaces* safely. Among other things, that means we can adapt *power armor* for human use with *software*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat continues talking with **Jinx Bubastis** as they head down the hall together towards the cargo bay.

Peter Cat

That doesn't solve the *anatomical differences*, but it eliminates a whole host of changes to the *control systems*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat and **Jinx Bubastis** have just opened the door to the cargo bay. They look surprised at what they see.

Jinx Bubastis

Hey, guys!
What's up?

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg and **Penny Skragg** are in the cargo bay, looking at a current newscast from Earth. The audio has been muted as a newscaster continues to speak. The chyron reads "ALIEN TERROR IN TULSA!". **Camillo Skragg** has a grim expression. **Penny Skragg** is in shock.

Camillo Skragg

There's been an incident.
Back home, on Earth.
It looks *really bad*.